Future Directions

At the MC8 the WTO members acknowledged the concerns on the global economic climate and agreed that:

(i) There is no credible alternative to the rules based multilateral trading system; and

(ii) Protectionist trade measures must be avoided.

The Chairman, in his summary report, stressed that the ***future work*** of the WTO must give priority to the development issues of LDCs, in particular cotton. Further, that the WTO needs to take into account the views of all its members. Despite the uncertainty surrounding the Doha negotiations, the MC8 has sent a clear message that the WTO remains relevant and important to world trade, as illustrated by the accessions of the Russian Federation, Montenegro, Samoa and Vanuatu. In his concluding remarks, Pascal Lamy stressed that despite these worrying economic times, *'don't chop off the branch you're sitting on…'* (a Russian proverb). The multilateral trading system is vital to world economic stability. *Finally*, the Doha negotiation impasse has led to members exploring new approaches to negotiating. Members were urged to have political courage and goodwill in concluding the DOHA round. The world is waiting for the next and the *Ninth Ministerial Coneference* of the WTO, scheduled to take place in **Bali** (December 3–6 , 2013).

BILATERAL AND REGIONAL COOPERATION

India has always stood for an open, equitable, predictable, non-discriminatory, and rule-based international trading system. Considering that regional and bilateral trade and economic cooperation agreements serve as building blocks towards achieving the multilateral trade liberalisation objective, India is actively engaging in regional and bilateral negotiations with her trading partner countries/blocs to diversify and expand the markets for its exports. Some of the recent developments related to major *Free Trade Agreements (FTAs)* are the following: